This rustic soup owes its substance to the beans. Buy fresh beans when they are available in early summer—they are quicker to cook and easier to digest.

pistou soup

SERVES 6–8 **PREP** 30 MINS **COOK** 1½ HOURS **FREEZE** UP TO 3 MONTHS WITHOUT THE PISTOU

for the pistou
3 garlic cloves, smashed and peeled
coarse sea salt, to taste
leaves from a large handful of fresh basil
2 small tomatoes, peeled, seeds removed and chopped (see p22)
freshly ground black pepper
1oz (25g) Parmesan cheese, grated
3 tbsp olive oil

1 ham hock, or a thick piece of smoked bacon, about 5½oz (150g)
7oz (200g) fresh white beans, such as cannellini, shelled
3½oz (100g) fresh red beans, such as borlotti, shelled
9oz (250g) flat green beans, sliced
2 medium floury potatoes, diced
3 tomatoes, peeled, seeds removed and chopped (see p22)
4 medium zucchini, chopped
salt and freshly ground black pepper
3½oz (100g) small macaroni noodles

1 To make the pistou, pound the garlic in a large mortar and pestle, then add a little salt and the basil and pound to a paste. Add the tomatoes and continue pounding and mixing until you have a thick sauce. Add pepper, the cheese, and the oil, mixing well, and adjust the seasoning.

2 For the soup, put 2 quarts (2 liters) cold water in a large stewing pot. Add the ham hock. Bring to a simmer, then partially cover and simmer gently for 30 minutes, skimming occasionally.

3 Meanwhile, put the white and red beans in a saucepan, cover with plenty of cold water, and bring to a boil. Simmer for 10 minutes, drain, and refresh. Add all the vegetables to the stewing pot. Season lightly. Return to a simmer, then partially cover and simmer for 1 hour, skimming occasionally.

4 Remove the ham hock and shred the meat. Remove half the ingredients out of the pan, mash with a fork, then return to the soup with the ham. Add the macaroni and cook until just tender. Stir in the pistou, and serve.